

Pahankanuwa Sermon #18

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Sahassamapi ce gāthā, anatthapadasaṃhitā; Ekaṃ gāthāpadaṃ
seyyo, yaṃ sutvā upasammati.*

From:

Verse 100 from the Sahassavagga (Chapter of Thousands) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

During the time the Buddha was residing at the Jetavana monastery, a certain large group of people set sail in a ship from a region in India (Jambudīpa). Out at sea, the ship broke apart, and almost all of those people drowned. Only one person, named Bāhiya, managed to grasp a wooden plank, swam with great difficulty, and landed at the port of Suppāraka. At this moment, this man did not even have proper clothing. He gathered pieces of wood, bound tree bark together with small pieces of wood, and made a garment for himself. Next, he went for alms in the villages around the Suppāraka port. Due to his unusual attire, the people took him to be an Arahant and treated him with great respect, offering him gifts and services. In the course of time, this person came to be known as 'Bāhiya Dārucīriya'. He was called 'Dārucīriya' because he wore a garment made of bark or tree bark. Thus, he spent his time living as an ascetic. Since everyone called him an Arahant, it occurred to him, "Perhaps I too am an Arahant." No sooner did this thought occur to him than a deity, who had been a relative of his in a past life, appeared and said, "Bāhiya, you are neither an Arahant nor have you entered the path to Arahantship." "Then who in this world is an Arahant?" he asked. The deity replied, "Far to the north, in the city of Sāvattthī, there resides the fully enlightened Buddha. It is he who has attained this state."

Immediately, a great faith and a strong desire arose in him to see the Buddha. It was a very long journey, a distance of many leagues (*yojanas*). Staying only one night at each place, traversing that long road, he went in search of the Buddha. He arrived at the Jetavana monastery in Sāvattihī early one morning. At the time of his arrival, the monks were walking up and down in the open air. He ran up to them and asked, "Where is the Blessed One, the Arahant, the Fully Self-Enlightened One? I have come in great haste just to see Him." The monks replied, "Bāhiya, the Buddha has entered the city for alms." Bāhiya did not stop there. He immediately ran after Him. As soon as he saw the Buddha walking for alms in Sāvattihī, a great faith arose in him. Seeing the Buddha, who was extremely peaceful and of serene senses, he prostrated at His feet and begged, "O Blessed One, please preach the Dhamma to me." For some reason, the Buddha said, "Bāhiya, this is not the time to preach the Dhamma. It is our time for alms-round." When this was said, Bāhiya pleaded, "O Blessed One, I do not know when the Blessed One's life might end, or when my own life might end. Therefore, please teach me at least a little Dhamma." Again the Buddha said, "No, Bāhiya, this is not the time to preach the Dhamma; it is the time of our alms-round." For the third time, he pleaded again, "O Blessed One, I do not know when the Blessed One's life might end, or when my own life might end. Therefore, please quickly preach even a little Dhamma." At that moment, the Buddha delivered a very brief sermon. Though it seemed simple, it was a sermon of deep meaning. Its meaning can be understood as follows:

"Therefore, Bāhiya, you should train yourself thus." *"*Tasmātiha Bāhiya evaṃ sikkhitabbaṃ.*"* "Therefore, Bāhiya, you should train yourself thus." In what way?

*"*Diṭṭhe diṭṭhamattaṃ bhavissati, sute sutamattaṃ bhavissati, mute mutamattaṃ bhavissati, viññāte viññātamattaṃ bhavissati.*"* "In the seen, there will be only the seen." This means let what is seen be merely what is seen. "In the heard, there will be only the heard." *"*Mute bhavissati*"*—**muta** refers to what is sensed. This is a term applied to what is sensed by the nose, the tongue, and the body. We can take it as sensing. The sensation of the nose, tongue, and body is a special kind of sensing, called **muta**. Thus, in the sensed, there will be only the sensed. *"*Viññāte bhavissati*"*—consciousness (**viññāṇa**) is the mind, is it not? In what is cognized by consciousness (**viññāṇa**), in what is known, or rather in what is thought—we can say in the known or the cognized, there will be only the cognized. *"*Evaṃ hi te Bāhiya*"*—Bāhiya, this is how you should train yourself.

Now, what was said earlier about training oneself in this way sounds like a very simple task. To let the seen be merely the seen, the heard be merely the heard, the sensed be merely the sensed, and the cognized by consciousness (**viññāṇa**)

be merely the cognized. When you have trained yourself in this manner, Bāhiya, when for you in the seen there is only the seen, in the heard only the heard, in the sensed only the sensed, and in the cognized only the cognized, then, Bāhiya, you are 'not by that' (or 'not thereof'). We will try to explain this later. You do not take that seen or heard thing as a 'thing' and grasp it. When you do not take it 'thereof' (as being made up of it), then you are 'not therein' (or 'not in there'). To be 'not therein' means you do not creep inside it. You do not enter into it.

"Yato kho te Bāhiya na tattha, tato tvam Bāhiya nevidha na huram na ubhayamantare."

"When you are not therein, then, Bāhiya, you are neither here, nor there, nor in between the two."

"Esevvanto dukkhassa." "This alone is the end of suffering (*dukkha*)." At first glance, it seems very easy to realize Nibbāna. This single passage is a meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*) leading all the way to Arahantship. A truly marvelous sermon. Even today, many scholars often bring up this Sutta discourse to showcase the essence of the Buddha's teaching. We do not know how many actually understand it. Nevertheless, for a meditative mind, even without much scholarly learning, these things can be understood, though they may be difficult for ordinary scholars. Thus, the Buddha gave Bāhiya a meditation subject that leads directly to the ultimate goal of Nibbāna—to the fruit of Arahantship. How effective was it? It is mentioned in the Sutta that immediately, as soon as the Buddha finished preaching this sermon, the bark-clad ascetic Bāhiya attained Arahantship right then and there. What a wonder! He became an Arahant; suffering (*dukkha*) ended right there. We will try to explain this slowly later on. But the story does not end there. We will explain certain things using the story, as it helps in understanding and is easier to keep in mind.

Next, the event is described as follows. Having delivered this sermon, the Buddha went for alms. Having finished his alms-round and consumed his meal, as he was leaving the city with the monks, he saw—what did he see? Arahant Bāhiya had not gone very far when a fierce cow with a young calf gored him to death. The ascetic Bāhiya was lying there dead—now Arahant Bāhiya. Only the Buddha knew his state. Seeing the body of this Arahant lying there, the Buddha said to the monks, "Monks, this is Bāhiya's body. Take it on a cot, cremate it, and build a stupa over his relics." The monks went to perform this task. They carried the body, cremated it, built a stupa, and returned to the Buddha to report what they had done. They said, "O Blessed One, we have cremated the body of that ascetic, as directed by the Blessed One. Where is he reborn?" Then the Buddha declared, "Monks, Bāhiya was very wise, highly intelligent, of great wisdom. He did not

trouble me much. He did not even trouble me to explain this in detail. Bāhiya attained Arahantship and attained *parinibbāna* (final extinguishment/extinction)." That was a truly wondrous event. Then the monks asked, "O Blessed One, when and by listening to what sermon did he attain Arahantship so quickly?" According to the Dhamma, it was then that this particular verse was spoken. Although there are other verses related to it, this one can be taken as a simple summary:

Sahassamapi ce gāthā, anattapadasaṃhitā,

Ekaṃ gāthāpadaṃ seyyo, yaṃ sutvā upasammati.

Better than a thousand verses comprised of meaningless words, is one word of a verse, hearing which one is stilled/pacified. The meaning of this verse is that a single word of a verse that leads to calming and tranquility upon hearing is far superior to a thousand meaningless verses. Now let us reflect a bit more on this story. Furthermore, it is mentioned in the Dhamma that on various occasions, the Buddha appointed different monks to the chief positions in various fields. Many of you may have heard of this. Ven. Sāriputta was chief among those of great wisdom, Ven. Moggallāna was chief among those with psychic powers. Thus the Buddha bestowed chief positions. Similarly, although the ascetic Bāhiya passed away shortly after, the Buddha declared to the monks, "He is your fellow companion in the holy life (*sābrahmacārī*)." The term *sābrahmacārī* is used for a monk. But even though he attained Arahantship while dressed in those clothes, the Buddha referred to him as a fellow companion in the holy life. Moreover, the Buddha declared, "In my dispensation, among those of swift intuition (*khippābhiññā*)—those who can comprehend the Dhamma very quickly—Bāhiya Dārucīriya is the chief."

A person with such great meritorious power had to undergo great suffering, swimming through the sea after the shipwreck, due to some karmic force. Then, shortly after becoming an Arahant, he had to pass away. However, there is a past-life story mentioned as to why he was able to understand the Dhamma so quickly. This is especially important for our times. What is it? During the time of Kassapa Buddha, Bāhiya Dārucīriya was one of a group of seven monks. These seven monks gathered and discussed among themselves during the period when the dispensation of Kassapa Buddha was declining. We can think about our own era too in this light; it must have been an era like this. This is what is called the 'period of decline', and as it was declining, these seven monks felt great urgency (*saṃvega*) and resolved, "Before this dispensation is destroyed, let us make an effort, sacrificing our lives, to realize Nibbāna." Having made this agreement and paying their final respects to the golden shrine of Kassapa Buddha, they entered

the forest and saw a large mountain. Before climbing this mountain, all seven agreed, "If there is anyone who still has a desire for life, let him turn back. If there is anyone who wishes to strive for Nibbāna, abandoning the desire for life, let him join." They built a ladder, climbed that great mountain, and then threw the ladder down.

How was the situation now? Now these venerable ones were on top of the rock. What was there left to do? There was only one thing to do: to meditate for the sake of escaping saṃsāra. The entire time, since there was no other way out—there was no ladder even to climb down—they began to meditate intensely. By the dawn of the next day, the senior monk, the chief Elder, became an Arahant possessed of direct knowledges (*abhiññā*). Having become an Arahant, it is mentioned that he walked through the air to Uttarakuru to obtain alms, and brought the food back. Perhaps out of custom, he invited the other monks to partake of the food. The other monks asked, "Venerable Sir, did we make such an agreement, that if one of us becomes an Arahant, we would eat the alms-food he brings?" "No, friends." "If so, Venerable Sir, you may partake of it. We will do what we can through our own strength." They again began to meditate intensely. On the second day, the second monk attained the state of Non-returning (*Anāgāmi*). That monk also flew through the air, brought alms-food, and made a similar invitation to the others. On that occasion too, they said, "Venerable Sir, did we make an agreement to reject the food brought by the chief Elder but accept the food brought by the second monk, and then meditate?" "Did we make such an agreement?" "No, friends." "Then we do not need that either. Somehow, by our own strength, if we are able, we will go and obtain alms." Saying this, the remaining five monks began to meditate intensely. After seven days, not only did their bodies become completely emaciated, but they strove in meditation until their last breath and died on that rock as worldlings (*puthujjana*).

Thus, the Arahant passed away into *parinibbāna*. The second monk, as an *Anāgāmi*, was reborn in the Brahma realm. These five monks—one of them was this ascetic Bāhiya Dārucīriya. The Dhamma also mentions the others. By the power of their intense effort, keeping the precepts (*sīla*), and meditation up to their last breath, they were reborn in the celestial realms and then took birth in various places during this era of our Buddha. One was born as King Pukkusāti. Another as Kumāra Kassapa, who later became a great Arahant; another as the wanderer Sabhiya; and another as Ven. Dabba Mallaputta, who attained Arahantship at the age of seven. They were born as outstanding individuals in this Buddha's dispensation. The fifth of them was Bāhiya Dārucīriya. Thus, the result of the life-sacrificing effort made by those five monks at the end of Kassapa Buddha's dispensation was their 'swift intuition' (*khippābhiññā*)—the ability to realize the Dhamma extremely fast in this dispensation. Thus, even in this era of

the decline of the Buddha's dispensation, this past event gives us great courage and inspiration from the example of these monks to meditate without giving up our efforts. We must reflect on this.

In the same way, let us look at the path to Nibbāna preached by the Buddha in relation to this verse. As we said at the beginning, this is something connected to the mind. Escaping from saṃsāra is a truly marvelous thing. Ultimately, one escapes by relying on wisdom (*paññā*). The Buddha's dispensation consists in developing virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). We have stated on many occasions: virtue is undertaken to discipline the body and speech. Having disciplined body and speech, the mind is then stilled through concentration. To the stilled mind, the true nature of the world becomes clear. The true nature of the world is not discovered by running after what is seen by the eye and heard by the ear, like chasing a mirage, and analyzing everything through science. Ultimately, the root of all this is the mind—thought itself. It is the understanding of thought. The day one understands thought, the net of Māra is broken. Why? Because thought itself is the bondage of Māra, whether for good or for bad, even though we cannot do without it. We are compelled to think. There are thoughts. That is why we mentioned at the very beginning: we use thought to understand everything. But the question is, how do we understand thought? It is to this that the Buddhas provide the answer through this Dhamma.

Now, let us try to unpack this brief sermon, analyze it, present it step-by-step, and bring it to a level where each of you can practice it. Here it was said: "in the seen, merely the seen." Here is another point to consider. One might wonder why the Buddha, who is so compassionate, rejected the request of an ascetic who had come from such a distance, traversing many yojanas, not just once but twice, saying, "This is not the time to preach, it is the time of our alms-round." We must understand that this was done with a very deep purpose. We can think of several reasons. First, when someone arrives completely exhausted and panting after a long journey, they are not ready to listen to the Dhamma. Only when they have rested a bit and calmed down can they focus their mind. Secondly, we can discern a skillful means (*upāya*) used by the Buddha. If the Buddha had said, "Very well, I will go for alms later. Sit down properly and take the five precepts," and started like that, the man's intense eagerness to receive the Dhamma would have diminished. Instead of that intense effort, he would have thought of it as a slow, leisurely journey. To prevent both of these, the Buddha acted as if he were in a great hurry. This prompted the thought, "Oh, please tell me just a little before you go." "Even a little is enough for me. If you are going for alms, I do not need a long sermon. Just tell me a tiny bit, and I will understand it." It is with this attitude that one listens. Thus, we can see two sides to this. On one hand, it allowed the person's exhaustion to subside. On the other hand, due to the skillful means of

the Buddha, the man became receptive to even a short sermon, ready to derive the maximum benefit from it, focusing his entire attention on listening. This is how, through such a short sermon, he understood the essence within the Buddha's Dhamma, as we mentioned earlier.

This Dhamma is something that gives a certain clue or skillful means to a person. Because understanding the nature of thought is something one must do for oneself. No one else can do it. Not even the Buddha can do it. He only shows the path, gives the skillful means, and directs one to it. Apart from that, nothing else can be done. This is something that belongs to each of you. With such a background, let us reflect on this. **Ditthe ditthamattam bhavissati**. Though we use the Pali words, there is no need to get flustered. In Sinhala, **dittha** means "what is seen". Why do we say "what is seen"? Generally, we use the expression "the seen thing". By saying "the seen thing", we are already caught. If we think of it as a "seen thing"... now, when it is about to rain, a rainbow appears. Everyone likes it. Is this rainbow a "thing"? Think about it. Is a rainbow a thing? A small child, seeing its beautiful colors, might think, "Oh, there is a rainbow! Dear mother, dear father, can you get that for me?" Someone could think like that. Is this something that can be grasped? How does this rainbow arise? At a time when it is about to rain, water vapor in the sky reflects the light from the setting sun. The sun is on one side. The color combination of the sun's light is what we call a rainbow. How many things have combined to form this? Just as the rainbow appeared, it disappears. The entire world is just like this rainbow. Yet we extract 'things' from these. Just as we make the rainbow into a 'thing', we make other things into 'things' as well. That is why we say "what is seen".

Let us think about it in another way. Looking from here—or rather, looking from one mountaintop towards another—it is a beautiful view. A perfect view to capture on camera. But if someone goes to that mountain to see that view up close, what do they see? The view they saw from afar is no longer there. Now this side looks beautiful from there. It is a mirage. This is what is called a mirage. It is just like that.

Therefore, the Buddha declared: stop at the seen in the seen. It is not about chasing the rainbow in an airplane or trying to catch it in some other way. It is a mirage-like thing that should be left right there and seen for what it is. It is the same with a mirage. This is why it is said: **ditthe ditthamattam bhavissati**—"in the seen, there will be only the seen." Do not go beyond that. Do not start thinking about it. This is the meaning here. If we contemplate this mirage analogy more deeply: you have heard that during the dry season, deer see the shimmering heat rising from the ground and run after it thinking it is water. Let us think for a moment. Generally, as the deer runs and runs, the mirage recedes.

Suppose the deer runs some distance, stops, and looks back. What then? The mirage is right where it started. Thus, if the deer looks back, it has to run back to where it came from. Having run there, when it looks back again, it has to run back. If you think about this, it might seem laughable. But this is exactly what we all do. Why? Because the truth is hidden from the deer. It ran after the mirage. Having run, if it looks back at some point, the mirage is on this side. So it runs all the way back. And goes again. This analogy will help us when we come to a certain point in this sermon.

Alright, keep that in mind. Next, let us see. "In the seen, there will be only the seen." Likewise, **sute sutamattam bhavissati**—"in the heard, there will be only the heard." This is the path of training the Buddha gave to Bāhiya. This is how one should train. A deep training is found here. Let there be only the heard in the heard. Bāhiya, regarding what is heard, let there be only the state of being heard. This is just like the seen. If we think about hearing, we do hear what is being spoken now. Not only that, you hear songs, hymns, and so on. To make them audible, many rhythms are joined together to create music. It is not the musician who made the music; it is you. You construct it yourselves. There is no need to go that far. Place a vessel where water is dripping. What do you hear? "Tick-tick-tick." Through that, you will hear a song. If your mind is inclined towards songs, if that is your preference, you will hear a song at that moment. If it is night, perhaps fear will arise. Who then constructs the songs out of that? We are all musicians. We construct songs. We construct rhythms. Where do these occur? On the eardrum. We are pleased by the sounds striking the eardrum—especially if they are praising us. If we perceive it as someone insulting us, we get agitated. These are all just sounds striking a drum. Through this, you can understand the deep insight (**vipassanā**) meaning of the advice the Buddha gave to Bāhiya. In the heard, let there be only the heard.

Next, in the sensed, there will be only the sensed. By "sensed" we mean what is experienced by the tongue, nose, and body. These are extremely subtle sensations. You know how dangerous the tongue is; the moment something touches the tongue, either the entire body is thrilled with pleasure, or the face contorts in distaste, finding it sour or bitter. Such a thing happens due to the sensitivity and power of the tongue. But even here, it is our mind that gathers them together in an extremely subtle manner. Think about it. We say sugar is sweet like honey. What taste is honey? It tastes like sugar. This too is like the deer running after the mirage. We say sugar is sweet by comparing it with honey. Because we have tasted honey, we say it tastes like honey. Next, when we take honey, we have to say it tastes like sugar. This is the trick played by the tongue. In the same way, let us think about touch. Something touches our body. At night, while we are sitting, something very soft brushes against our body. We think,

"Oh, this is something very soft," and we touch it. The moment we touch it—it's a cobra! The cobra bites. There is that touch. In this way, first came the feeling, not the sensation of danger, but the moment it is seen as something dangerous, everything changes. The Buddha presents through this the wonderful deception that occurs through our sense faculties. Therefore, if you want wisdom (*paññā*), if you want to escape from saṃsāra, if you want to break the net of Māra, if you want to be free from the mirage, do this. If you want to live in the world, if you want to cultivate saṃsāra, if you want to go further in saṃsāra, none of this is necessary. Remain subject to thought just as before. That is all there is to the Dhamma.

Thus, the "sensed" can be understood in that way. *Viññāte viññātamattam* means in the cognized, only the cognized. Generally, let us think about this mass of knowledge in the world—books in libraries, the forces of what is called the wonderful science in the world. Through all of these, with a certain pride, we think, "I know." This is taken as knowledge, as knowing. To distinguish one thing from another is the primary function of consciousness (*viññāṇa*). To distinguish between the bitter taste and the sweet taste is a function of consciousness (*viññāṇa*). Distinguishing feelings (*vedanā*) as pleasant, painful, or neutral is also consciousness (*viññāṇa*). Through consciousness (*viññāṇa*), we distinguish and know. We separate one thing from another. We taste it and separate: "this is bitter, this is sweet." Similarly, is this pleasant or painful? What is felt as pleasant is realized to be painful after a while. The state where both are absent is distinguished as neutral. In this way, there is an extremely subtle tendency to analyze in our consciousness (*viññāṇa*). We understand by dividing and presenting. There is a nature in consciousness (*viññāṇa*) to separate things as "this is this, and the other is that." Whichever it may be, the Buddha says here: if there is something cognized in that way, consider it merely as something cognized. Do not go beyond that. Do not build further upon it. This is what *viññātamattam bhavissati* means. Now let us come to the deeper part.

First, Bāhiya was given the path of training. "Train yourself in this way." For you, we gave a simpler thing: we started by giving only the Ajīvattamakasīla (eight precepts with livelihood as the eighth) to restrain body and speech. But for Bāhiya Dārucīriya, the Buddha first gives this deep restraint of the senses (*indriya-saṃvara-sīla*). What is found here is the restraint of the senses, not ordinary virtue. Here lies a deep virtue of restraint and self-control, which is helpful for anyone wishing to attain Arahantship. Thus, if one has developed such discipline, restraint, and training regarding everything seen, heard, sensed, and thought, so that one stops at that measure and does not go beyond—then,

Bāhiya—as is said next—what happens then? The Buddha declares: "Then, Bāhiya, you are *not by that* (or *not thereof*)." That is a deep idea. What is meant by "not by that"? As said before, making it a "thing". Let us go back to the rainbow. The child who made the rainbow into a "thing" cries to his mother, "I will not sleep until you give me that rainbow. Somehow give me that rainbow." That child thinks of it by making it a "rainbow", not as a mere seen thing. It is a real thing, something that can be obtained. In the same way, the child then lives in the rainbow, inside the rainbow. He will even see it in his dreams. This is a small analogy used according to the occasion. This can be understood.

"Na tena"—Then, Bāhiya, when you are "not by that" (or "not thereof")—"not thereof" meaning you do not go on to think in terms of the seen, the heard, the sensed, the thought, or the conceptualized—then, Bāhiya, you are "not therein" (or "not in there"). You are not in the *diṭṭha* (seen). Let us give an illustration for this too. When a man builds a fine bungalow, what does he do out of great pride? He stands in front of it and has a photographer take a picture. What does this show? The bungalow and the gentleman. When looking at that picture, the person is inside the picture.

In the same way, using this analogy, think: if at any moment you do not give rise to pride regarding that, if there is no grasping through craving (*taṇhā*), conceit (*māna*), and views (*diṭṭhi*)—these words can be understood in this context—if you do not generate defilements in that way, then you are "not therein". You are not inside that *diṭṭha* (seen). You are not inside that music. That delusion is not there. In the same way, you are not inside what is sensed. They are just as they are, in their respective places. What we expect from the Dhamma preached by the Buddha is the knowledge and vision of things as they really are (*yathā-bhūta-ñāṇa-dassana*). The Buddha shows the truth as it is. He does not show what is non-existent as existent. The Buddhas appear in the world to show what is non-existent as non-existent, and what is existent as existent. This is exactly what is said here. In the seen there should be only the seen; do not grow anything further upon it. Do not allow its branches and leaves to grow. If you allow them, it will drag you, due to defilements, either to lust, hatred, or delusion, and to various other defilements. Therefore, the Buddha gives a strict training here. Let there be only the measure of the seen in the seen. What happens when it is like that? Then, you are "not thereof". When you are "not thereof", you are also "not therein". When you are "not therein"—here comes the deepest part: *yato kho te Bāhiya na tattha, tato tvam Bāhiya nevidha na huram na ubhayamantare, esevvanto dukkhassa*. If so, Bāhiya, you are neither here, nor there, nor in between the two. This alone is the end of suffering (*dukkha*). This is Nibbāna.

Now let us reflect on this—we have to bring the story of the deer in here too. When we reach the state of being trained in that manner, how does the mind understand it? "You are not here." Even the feeling "I am here" disappears. Why? Because the very premise, the concept of "myself" and "others", of "myself" and the "world", which has been carried throughout saṃsāra, is erased by vipassanā wisdom (*paññā*). Then you are neither here, nor there, nor in between. Now, we said about the deer that it ran a long distance after seeing the mirage and then looked back. Looking back, the mirage was right here. It ran back. When it looked back from here, it was over there. In this way, the deer collapses in exhaustion from running after the mirage. We can state this in two ways. If it goes on running without looking back, it will eventually collapse and die. If it runs back and forth between here and there, it will collapse and die of exhaustion.

Now, dear devotees, think about this. What is being done in this saṃsāra? Most of the time, you perform meritorious deeds not only for this world but for the next world. There is "this world" and "the other world". You perform meritorious deeds to secure something for the next world. That is not bad; it is good. Through merit and wholesome deeds, the mind is purified. But suppose we distribute one oil cake (*kāvum*) to the monks for the Alms-round. And we wish: "May I receive a thousand oil cakes like this." Well, let us suppose that as a result, we receive ten thousand oil cakes. After that is over, or let us say we are born in a celestial world by the power of that merit. After that merit is exhausted, we have to come back to the human world, cook oil cakes, and give them in charity again. There too, it is just like the work of that deer. There is no satisfaction, no contentment. Here, satisfaction or contentment would mean what is necessary to quench the deer's thirst. What is that? Water. That shimmering heat in the distance looks like water. Therefore, it goes in search of water. It does not get water. It has to come back, because water is seen. Similarly, the saṃsāric being enjoys fivefold sensual pleasures as much as possible in this world. Eating, drinking, dancing, doing everything with the wealth received due to past merit. Yet, one is not satisfied. Therefore, what does one do? Somehow, one distributes at least one oil cake and wishes for ten-million-fold results. But whether that is received or not, one comes back to this very same place. One is running after a mirage.

Now, one should not misunderstand this as a statement against performing meritorious deeds. But there is such a wondrous thing in this Middle Path, the Dhamma of the Buddha. That is why this Dhamma is called a diamond (Vajra-maṇi). You know what a diamond is. It is a gem that can cut other gems. The Buddha's Dhamma is like that. It cuts through everything. Even the things we hold on to, like meritorious deeds, a time comes when we have to let go of them too. That is what the Buddha deeply declares: do not grasp anything. But this is not something that can be done all at once. First, through virtue (*sīla*) and

other wholesome qualities, one achieves calming to some level. Then, by developing concentration (*samādhi*) and meditation, the mind is stilled. One does not remain stuck in any of these. One is not satisfied with them. One does not stop, thinking, "Now I am a very virtuous person." One does not stop, thinking, "Now I have attained great concentration and jhānas, I can fly through the air." What is the ultimate thing? Liberation from saṃsāra lies in wisdom (*paññā*). Therefore, wisdom is compared to a diamond. It cuts through every other gem. It is truly wonderful. It penetrates through everything.

Here too, what was done was a penetration. Why is it said to stop at the seen in the seen—merely the seen? What usually happens? One goes into the seen and gets entangled. We have seen this many times—for instance, a dog on a footbridge—or you might have heard the story of a jackal carrying a piece of meat across a footbridge. Seeing his reflection in the water, he thought another jackal was carrying a piece of meat, let go of his own piece, and jumped in to snatch it. In the same way, being deceived by this *diṭṭha* (the seen), how much does the saṃsāric being suffer? Because of the wrong understanding and the wrong path of thought generated through this, day and night, based on some sight seen, a person dedicates and sacrifices their entire life, falling into delusion. But they do not understand the true situation. Without making this a riddle, let us say: suppose a person, whether a man or a woman, sees someone they desire. Through the thought generated by this, they lose sleep, and then, even killing others, they try to win that person, and finally fall into the states of deprivation (*apāya*). Why does all this happen? Because they did not stop at the seen in the seen. They took it to be a "person". They took it to be an "individual". They thought, "This is someone who can be with me forever." But the Arahants of the past, like Bāhiya Dārucīriya, sacrificed their lives for something else. But today, people throw down ladders and do everything for the sake of this saṃsāra. Therefore, we must understand such matters: to "be merely the seen in the seen" means to develop a state of mind that is not deceived by that mirage. In terms of worldly convention (*sammuti*), we have to use terms like 'things' for our daily activities. But we must penetrate them with wisdom (*paññā*).

You know what it means to penetrate something. If someone looks at something with a power that penetrates it, even after removing it, it appears just as it is. In this way, it is said that one attains mental liberation (*cetto-vimutti*) through the power of wisdom (*paññā*). Therefore, the person who has attained vipassanā wisdom can see that true nature. But they do not end their life on that account; they carry on with other activities. The experience gained through that wisdom is embedded within them. It is embedded inside the mind. So much so, that at the moment of final passing away, like Arahant Bāhiya Dārucīriya, they do not take birth again, having escaped from saṃsāra. They have escaped from those

samsāric thoughts. Arahant Bāhiya Dārucīriya broke those thoughts. That is why it is said he attained parinibbāna. Arahants do not die. The word 'die' can be used in the world. But along with the word 'die' goes its counterpart, 'is born'. These go in pairs, in couples. That is what we meant by 'here' and 'there'. There is a 'there' and a 'here'. We have built fences and barriers. When we build them, there is also a 'middle'. That is why it was said, "You are not in the middle either." One might ask, "If I am not here, and if I am not there, I must be in the middle." That is the logic of the world. You know there are parties in the world. Even when thinking about them, it is like that. Either you must be here, or you must be there, or you must be in the middle. Here we have a truly wonderful thing. Bāhiya, you are neither here, nor there, nor in the middle between the two. Why? Because ultimately, even this usage of 'exists' and 'does not exist' comes to an end. Ultimately, in the Buddha's Dhamma, this existence (*bhava*), which is held in high esteem by every religious teacher in the entire world, is not a real existence, but merely a conceit of existence. It is only an illusion, a delusion, a deception created by the mind.

It is upon this delusion that one runs—between there and here, between the next world and this world, between the human world and the heaven world. In this way, there is no end to this running journey. There is no end to those aspirations. This is what a Buddha introduces to the world. It is for this that Buddhas fulfill the paramis (perfections) for four incalculable aeons and a hundred thousand cosmic cycles. Not to teach some social or political philosophy. Although they spoke of those things in passing, this is the core of the Buddha's teaching.

The secret of escaping from this entire samsāra is preached by the Buddha as a skillful means, according to the character and capacity of each individual. If someone understood that skillful means at that moment, through a single verse, they realized Nibbāna. Therefore, you can understand that there is a very great depth in this sermon. It appears deep, in fact, to a person who has not developed the mind through meditation. Bāhiya Dārucīriya might not have been a person with academic degrees. He was a person who lived a hard life after his ship was wrecked in the sea. But relying on the power of the paramis (perfections) accumulated in the past, he attained Arahantship extremely fast through such a short sermon. Therefore, we must understand that worldly knowledge is something that piles up. Subject to it, many people are crushed—living their lives crushed by knowledge. Sometimes, because of knowledge itself, they engage in various cunning deeds and ultimately go to the states of deprivation. It is not knowledge that is truly needed, but wisdom (*paññā*). Wisdom is a capacity of understanding, something that penetrates. It is like the diamond. It cannot be bought with books, money, or academic degrees. The path to it is virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*).

Now, on this valuable Full Moon Poya day, you have undertaken virtue (*sīla*)—I believe most of you have. Others too should strive. Meditation means developing the mind. It is not something that belongs only to the monks. Now, this Bāhiya Dārucīriya was wearing bark-garments, he did not even have a robe, yet he attained Arahantship. In the same way, you must reflect: even though we are in lay life, what we must do is walk on this path of training. Therefore, based on virtue (*sīla*), having restrained body and speech, we must then still the mind. Primarily, first, a concentration (*samādhi*), some meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*). For that, sometimes big words are not needed. A single phrase like "May all beings be well and happy" or "Arahant"—stilling one's mind on a wholesome object using such a phrase is what is called concentration (*samādhi*). If you still the mind in that way, to a great extent, the running of the mind stops. But it is not finished. Going deeper than that is vipassanā wisdom.

Thus, the essence of that is what was contained in the sermon we delivered. In truth, the Buddha has presented the threefold training of virtue, concentration, and wisdom in this sermon in a way that suited Bāhiya's capacity of understanding. We too must gather from this at our own level, in a way that helps our lives. We must think of this entire saṃsāra as a dream. Sometimes, one might feel afraid of this. But think about your own dreams. A dream is real at the time you are dreaming it. Finally, when you wake up, the things that appeared as real in the dream are completely different. Sometimes, what you ate thinking it was delicious food was actually your pillow. It is the same with other things. Those are the dreams seen at night. In truth, think about your entire past. Looking back at the entire past from your childhood, your childhood, youth, achievements—when these elderly gentlemen think about them, aren't they like a dream? The past is like the dream you saw yesterday. Next, let us think about the future, for which we have created these great aspirations. Think of some situation as a dream you will see tonight—that it will appear tonight. Then, what about the little we do today? The word to describe it might be something laughable—like a daydream. Such is this existence (*bhava*). That is why the Buddha declared the entire saṃsāric existence to be an illusion, a magic trick. The Buddha compared consciousness (*viññāṇa*) to a mirage or a magician's trick, which shows what is non-existent as existent.

Therefore, according to this Bāhiya Sutta, why do we stop at the seen in the seen? There is nothing to be taken as a 'seen thing'. There is nothing to be taken as a 'heard thing'. Just like what we said about the rainbow, music, and the mirage. But we imagine them. There is a lot of imagining in the world. Without it, according to our conventions (*sammuti*), we cannot speak. We cannot talk to others in our language of vipassanā. Therefore, conventionally, we have to say "a rainbow is rising" or "it is raining". Think about whether the rain is separate from

the raining. "It is raining." Here, the rain is the raining thing. The action is raining. Can we separate these two? We cannot, can we? In the same way, there is only a heap of preparations (*saṅkhāra*) here. A heap of formations (*saṅkhāra*). Out of this, we construct a world. Having constructed and fashioned it, we divide it, build fences, and say 'there' and 'here'—this saṃsāric journey is what we do as 'the other world' and 'this world'. This entire saṃsāric existence (*bhava*) is something that belongs neither to the other world nor to this world. That is why the Buddha preached stopping instead of continuing. Nibbāna means stopping, extinguishment. This is not something pleasing to the ordinary world. The world likes burning and running. To the world that likes burning and running, the invitation to extinguishment and stopping might sometimes be unpleasing. But the Buddhas say only this. The Buddha's teaching is just this. Therefore, stop, be extinguished—it is for this that the Buddha preached such sermons. Those who have stopped and are extinguished in this way are called Arahants.

Thinking in this way, on this valuable Poya day, you listened to a sermon that the ordinary world dismisses as too deep, thinking it cannot be understood in this day and age. But we believe that even though you are village devotees, if you have directed your mind towards meditation, you possess the capacity, at least to some extent, to understand even such sermons. To develop this capacity further in the future, go to those from whom you can get advice, develop all your mental powers as serenity (*samatha*) and insight (*vipassanā*). Strive to further develop the faculties (*indriya*) and powers (*bala*) of faith (*saddhā*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) generated during this sermon. May you derive the strength and power to escape from this dangerous saṃsāra, to be freed from those thoughts, and to find peace in the supreme deathless Nibbāna in this very life by realizing the paths and fruits of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti*), Once-returning (*Sakadāgāmi*), Non-returning (*Anāgāmi*), and Arahantship.

Likewise, may the merit we have accumulated today through this Dhamma sermon, and the merit accumulated through listening to the Dhamma, be shared with the guardian deities and Brahmas of the Dispensation, and with all beings from the Avīci hell up to the Akaniṭṭha heaven, including our departed relatives. May they all rejoice in this merit, and by rejoicing, may they all realize peace in the supreme deathless Nibbāna through their aspired mode of enlightenment (*bodhi*). Dedicate the merits by reciting the verses in this manner.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”